

04 Numbers and statistics

Fractions, decimals, and percentages are all pronounced differently in spoken English, following a few simple rules.

-  **New language** Numbers in spoken English
-  **Vocabulary** Sports events
-  **New skill** Using numbers in conversation

4.1 KEY LANGUAGE FRACTIONS

You might see fractions written out as words. Aside from “half” and “quarter,” the bottom number of a fraction is written or spoken as an ordinal number.

$\frac{1}{4}$

a quarter

Use ordinal numbers for the bottom of a fraction.

$\frac{1}{3}$

a third

$\frac{1}{2}$

a half

Use cardinal numbers for the top of a fraction.

$\frac{3}{5}$

three fifths

Use “and” to link a whole number and a fraction.

$1\frac{1}{2}$

one and a half



4.2 KEY LANGUAGE DECIMALS

Decimals are always written as numbers, not words. The decimal point is pronounced “point,” and all numbers after the decimal point are spoken separately.

point five

0.5

nought point five

zero point five

There are three ways of saying decimals that begin with 0.

1.7

one point seven

3.97

three point nine seven

You don't say “three point ninety-seven.”

Decimal points are written in English using a period, or full stop.



4.3 KEY LANGUAGE PERCENTAGES

The % symbol is written and spoken as “percent.” You might also see “per cent” written in UK English. Percentages are normally written as numbers, not words.

1%

one percent

99%

ninety-nine percent

55.5%

fifty-five point five percent

The % symbol is pronounced “percent.”

